

NFR — Failure-Mode Checklist

Day 3 · Activity 1 handout. The five ways NFRs go wrong. Most PRD templates ship with terrible boilerplate NFRs — this is the eye you calibrate before writing your own. Check every NFR against all five.

The five NFR failure modes

Failure mode	What it looks like	The fix
Boilerplate	"Performance must be acceptable"	Copy-pasted from a template — rewrite for <i>your</i> feature and users
Unmeasurable	"The system shall be highly available"	Attach a number and a condition you can observe at runtime
No defense	"p95 latency < 100ms" (no rationale — why this number?)	Add the scenario that justifies the target
No verification	"The system shall be secure" (how would we ever know?)	State how it's tested/observed in pre-prod or production
Wrong category	A "Performance" NFR that's actually a feature requirement	Ask "what would a Performance test for this look like?" — if there isn't one, recategorize

The sneaky one is Wrong category. It surfaces only when you ask what a test *in that category* would even look like. **The most common one is Boilerplate** — usually the result of "we copied the template." Name it openly.

What a clean NFR has (the four-part shape)

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### NFR – <short name>
**Category:** Performance / Security / Accessibility / Observability /
Compliance
**Requirement:** <specific, measurable target>
**Defense:** <why this number; what scenario justifies it>
**Verification:** <how we test/observe it>
```

Triage pass/fail sheet

NFR	Boilerplate	Unmeasurable	No defense	No verification	Wrong category	Clean?
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						